spectrum case), was appointed chairman of the Supreme Court-mandated Committee of Administrators (CoA) to set things right in the BCCI.

The CoA was empowered to implement the Justice Lodha Panel recommendations and make cricket transparent in India. It did, however, run into problems almost immediately. Two of the four CoA members—historian Ramachandra Guha and banker Vikram Limaye—resigned within months for different reasons. The other two, Rai and former India women's captain Diana Edulji, survived the 33-month roller-coaster ride together, all the time at loggerheads with recalcitrant BCCI officials, and often among themselves. In this period, Rai had a ringside view of how BCCI, the ultra-rich but notoriously opaque sports body, functions. He was also witness to some melodramatic developments in Indian cricket.

Rai clearly has an eye for detail and understands administration like the back of his hand. His passion for cricket is also patent. My gripe is that the book meanders into the minutiae of administration while some important and more interesting issues that erupted during his 33-month tenure (January 2017-September 2019) have been dealt with inadequately.

Take, for instance, the Kumble-Kohli split that led to one of the most unsavoury chapters in contemporary Indian cricket, or the rift between Mithali Raj and Harmanpreet Kaur, which almost tore apart women's cricket. Both these events were tumultuous, and Rai is sympathetic to all parties in these conflicts. He gets Mithali and Harmanpreet to sit with him in a meeting and thrash out their differences, but why this does not happen in the Kumble-Kohli fracas is not entirely clear.

In matters directly involving players, VINOD RAI takes an equidistant, diplomatic position, typical of risk-averse bureaucrats

While the book discusses several issues pertaining to the BCCI in detail, in matters directly involving players, Rai pulls his punches, taking an equidistant, diplomatic position, typical of risk-averse bureaucrats. For someone empowered by the apex court to fix problems, Rai does not seem to take a more exploratory or adventurous approach.

Overall, though, *Not Just a Nightwatchman* is an interesting read—told simply, giving readers a window into how cricket is managed in the country. There are several names dropped along the way, but not without relevance. My only complaint would be that Rai is perhaps a tad too deferential to players, especially 'legends', a word he uses repeatedly. Not all 'legends', we know, have been embellishments to the game.

The thrust of the book is about cricket administration in India, and Rai zooms in on the main reason for the malaise despite the zillions that the BCCI has at its command: "There are some families who have made it a full-time vocation merely to own and manage state associations or be office-bearers in the BCCI. They are never required to prove their mettle. If Sachin Tendulkar's son has had to demonstrate his skills to earn his place in Mumbai's senior squad, why shouldn't an administrator's son, daughter, brother or even wife prove their mettle?"

Why indeed?! ■

–Ayaz Memon

lost a Test when Vishwanath made a century, and won most famously in Trinidad, chasing over 400. Brian Johnston called Vishwanath the 'compleat' batsman and rated him above Gavaskar, an assessment the latter agreed with.

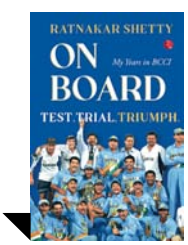
Wrist Assured tells us much about the public Vishwanath (despite the occasional irritant of referring to himself in the third person), but little of the private person beyond the effort he put in to make everything look effortless. Wouldn't we have loved to know how he met and married Gavaskar's sister Kavita, for example?

This is a book both for those who love him and the IPL generation which needs reminding how special he was. And how a special gift can be nurtured and is rewarded regardless of background if you have the steel. ■

–Suresh Menon

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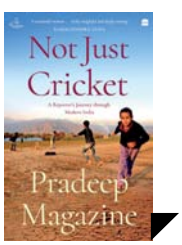
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